
lockmgr API Reference

Release 1.10.1

Gene C

Sep 09, 2026

LOCKMGR API REFERENCE:

1	lockmgr	1
1.1	Overview	1
1.2	Recent Changes	1
1.3	Signed Source	2
1.4	Using LockMgr Class	2
1.5	Research on file locking	3
1.6	C Examples	4
1.7	Python Examples	4
2	API Reference	7
2.1	class LockMgr	7
3	Appendix	9
3.1	Installation	9
3.2	Dependencies	9
3.3	License	9
	Python Module Index	11

LOCKMGR

1.1 Overview

lockmgr provides a Python class implementing file locking.

The API reference doc in both PDF and HTML is included.

1.2 Recent Changes

1.10.1

- Drop unused pytest from meson.build (thank you @piater)

1.10.0

- Bug in meson test runner with PYTHONPATH - One of those mornings ...

1.9.7

- Test now runs several processes in parallel waiting to acquire lock

1.9.5

- meson now runs tests.
- Clean html docs to avoid unneeded sphinx tmp files.
- Fix bug with tests using relative path as reported by @piater on AUR

1.9.4

- Fix missing makedepends and ensure build/install scripts fail on error Thanks to @TrialnError on Arch AUR.

1.9.1

- Use meson / meson-python for build and package management
- Periodic review
- Small code adjustments.
- Add check to PKGBUILD
- please delete any /usr/lib/python3.14/site-packages/lockmgr/__pycache__ before installing. See important note below.

**** IMPORTANT ****

Some older versions of this package did not include any byte compiled cache (`__pycache__`) and python auto creates them at runtime at a later date. If this exists, please delete the directory before installing this version since it now includes the `.pyc` files. This will avoid pacman error that a `.pyc` file exists. So before upgrade please do:

```
/usr/bin/rm -rf /usr/lib/python3.14/site-packages/lockmgr/__pycache__
```

My apologies.

1.3 Signed Source

All git tags are signed with `arch@sapience.com` key which is available via WKD or download from <https://www.sapience.com/tech>. Add the key to your package builder gpg keyring. The key is included in the Arch package and the `source=` line with `?signed` at the end can be used to verify the git tag. You can also manually verify the signature

1.4 Using LockMgr Class

Using the class is straightforward. Choose a file to use as the lockfile - avoid NFS mounts. I find using `/tmp` works well since it's a `tmpfs` file system.

An sample application is available in the examples directory. To see it in action, simply run `test_lock.py` in 2 different terminals. One process will acquire the lock while the other will wait until its released.

Typical usage:

```
import os
from lockmgr import LockMgr

lockdir = '/tmp/xxx'
os.makedirs(lockdir, exist_ok=True)
lockfile = os.path.join(lockdir, 'foo.lock')
lockmgr = LockMgr(lockfile)

...

# Acquire lock
if lockmgr.acquire_lock(wait=True, timeout=30):
    # do stuff
    ...

    # release lock
    lockmgr.release_lock()
else:
    # failed to get lock
    ...
```

1.5 Research on file locking

I share my notes and research on file locking. All code samples are available in the examples/research directory.

Linux: C File Locking has linux kernel support via standard C library using `fcntl()`. The mechanism uses 'struct flock' as the communication mechanism with (posix) `fcntl()`.

The standard locking mechanism uses `F_SETLK`. This lock lives at the process level and is the original locking in linux. Around 2015 or so 'open file description' locks came to be via `F_OFD_SETLK` (See¹ and²). These are at the open file level. So while `F_SETLK` is not passed to child processes, OFD locks are. And OFD locks remain attached to the open file handle. This can be enormously useful and also surprising.

Posix locks are attached to (inode, pid) pair which means they work at the process level. If thread opens same file, even tho has different file handle, when that thread closes the fd, the lock is released for all threads in same process.

OFD locking was introduced to deal with this. Locking is attached to the "open file" and not the PID.

linux also provides "lockf" which is a wrapper around `fcntl()` locks - should only be used in simple cases and will interact with "normal" `fcntl()` locks - caveat emptor.

Summary:

- Posix Lock: `fcntl()` - `F_SETLK`
- OFD Lock: `fcntl()` - `F_OFD_SETLK`
- `lockf` - bah

NB. The flock struct contains `l_pid` - this MUST be 0 for OFD locks and PID for posix locks.

Its also worth noting that locking can be file system dependent. In particular NFS should probably be avoided. Since my dominant use case is single machine, multiple process, I use `/tmp` which is a TMPFS file system and works well.

Python Python provides for same locking mechanisms - I recommend only 1 way for file locks in python. Python library provides for:

- `fcntl.fcntl` => do not use

As with C there is support for `F_SETLK` and `F_OFD_SETLK`. While these work fine, they require using 'struct' module to 'pack' and 'unpack' the C flock struct. To make this work the caller must provide the sizes (coded with letters as per the python struct module) of each element being packed.

The python 3.12 docs have examples³, and while they may well work for a Sun workstation or similar, if you have one, the struct element sizes dont seem correct for X86_64.

I provide a little C-program to print out the correct byte sizes which you can then map to the python struct letter codes⁴

This approach is brittle - its one thing when you are coding with your own C structures, its another entirely when using system ones - these sizes should be compiled into python - while these routines work I strongly recommend not using them for this reason.

- `fcntl.lockf` => do not use

¹ File private locks <https://lwn.net/Articles/586904/>

² Open File Description <https://lwn.net/Articles/640404/>

³ Python fcntl docs: <https://docs.python.org/3/library/fcntl.html>

⁴ Python struct module: <https://docs.python.org/3/library/struct.html>

Wrapper around `fcntl()` - in spite of name this is NOT C `lockf()` function.

- `fcntl.flock` => *use this one*

Wrapper around `fcntl` with OFD support. i.e. this lock is associated with open file descriptor. This is what I use and recommend.

1.6 C Examples

Sample code for `F_SETLK` and `F_OFD_SETLK` To compile:

```
make
```

Builds 2 programs - `flock_sizes` and `c_lock_test`.

`flock_sizes` is used To print size of struct flock elements which provide the correct sizes to use in python `fcntl.fcntl` approach.

```
./flock_sizes
```

The test program demonstrates locking with and without OFD. To run the test program see the [Tests: c_lock_test](#) section below.

Tests: c_lock_test To run locking tests, use 2 terminals. Run `c_lock_test` in both. The first will acquire lock while second will fail until first exits or is interrupted.

Test 1 : Using `F_SETLK`

```
./c_lock_test
```

Test 2 : Using `F_OFD_SETLK`

Repeat test but with argument to turn on OFD

```
./c_lock_test ofd
```

Test (1) and (2) both work.

1.7 Python Examples

lock_fcntl F_SETLK and F_OFD_SETLK tests in python. Run test in 2 terminals as above:

Test 3 : F_SETLK

```
./lock_fcntl.py
```

Test 4 : F_OFD_SETLK

```
./lock_fcntl.py ofd
```

Test (3) and (4) both work.

lock_flock This is what I am using. As above, run test in 2 terminals.

Test 5

```
./lock_fcntl.py
```

Test (5) works.

API REFERENCE

This section contains the API guide for the `lockmgr` module.

2.1 class `LockMgr`

locking

`class lockmgr.LockMgr(lockfile)`

Bases: `object`

Robust file locking manager.

`acquire_lock(wait: bool = False, timeout: int = 30) → bool`

Try to acquire a lock.

Parameters

- `wait` – If True and `timeout > 0`: wait until lock is acquired (up to 10 attempts). This can be racy from the time `inotify` returns till we acquire lock will fail and we will try again. If False, then do not retry if unable to acquire lock on first attempt.
- `timeout` – Number of seconds `> 0` to wait between attempts to acquire the lock. Will retry up to 10 times.

Returns

True if lock acquired else False

`release_lock()`

Release an Acquired Lock

No-op if there is no acquired lock.

Returns

None

APPENDIX

3.1 Installation

Available on

- [Github](#)
- [Archlinux AUR](#)

On Arch you can build using the provided PKGBUILD in the packaging directory or from the AUR. To build manually, clone the repo and

```
./scripts/do-build  
./scripts/do-install <destination-dir>
```

3.2 Dependencies

- Run Time :
 - python (3.14 or later)
- Building Package:
 - git
 - meson
 - meson-python
 - rsync

3.3 License

Created by Gene C. and licensed under the terms of the GPL-2.0-or-later license.

- SPDX-License-Identifier: GPL-2.0-or-later
- SPDX-FileCopyrightText: © 2023-present Gene C <arch@sapience.com>

PYTHON MODULE INDEX

l

lockmgr, 7